



Who needs photo printers?

Photo printers are available for home as well as for businesses. At home, they serve the purpose of having a photo lab as and when you need it. Borderless printing, which was not possible except in print labs, is now possible at home. You can print in regular sizes, and also photo print on stickers and other media.



HP 7960

For businesses, a photo printer may be advantageous if you need good quality prints regularly. For example, if you need to send out a few exclusive, high-quality invites to some clients, you may find it difficult to get it done from your regular print shop. Photo printers can be useful for creative designers, architects and engineers; there are many applications, such as AutoCAD, which make a photo printer a very handy thing to have.

Ink quality

A basic principle: Don't ever be stingy with your colour cartridges. If you demand the best, use the best. Saving a few rupees by using a fake or refilled cartridge will not give you the output that you expect. Always use manufacturer-branded or recommended cartridges and papers. Technologies such as HP's PhotoREt colour layering technology or Epson's water-proof ink technology are not possible with refilled cartridges.

What do I buy?

The HP 7960 is an interesting model. This printer gave the best results for photo printing in tests, and, at Rs 16,999, is targeted towards the mid to high-end consumer segment. It comes with frills such as a memory card reader, and direct connectivity to an HP digital camera, but lack of PictBridge means non-HP cameras are not supported—PictBridge is a standard that allows you to directly connect a wide range of digicams directly to your printer.

The Canon i905D is comparable to the HP printer. It supports PictBridge technology, and is priced at Rs 21,995. Image printouts turned out to be of very good quality. However, it is not very good at text printing. The Epson Stylus Photo 900 has decent image quality, but loses on connectivity options. Also, the prints lack tonal balance, where the HP excels, and the Canon follows suit with almost similar quality.

While all these are good desktop photo printers, Canon's new portable solutions, the CP-200 and the CP-300, priced at Rs 11,195 and Rs 16,995 respectively, are viable options. These printers, based on the dye-sublimation technology, can provide you with instant photographs anywhere, since they can run on a portable battery. Since portability is the main criterion here, both printers support PictBridge technology, giving you printouts directly from your digital camera. Dye-sublimation-based portable solutions are also available from Sony, Epson, HP and Kodak. Offering a variation in terms of both features and price, these manufacturers have models that suit every budget. ■

bhaskar_banik@thinkdigit.com

1/2 Pg V AD